



Did you know that digital SLRs still use mechanical shutters?

Trick Photography ...isn't so tricky

Rossi Fernandes

We've always told you which cameras to buy and how to shoot photographs the right way, but there should also be time for fun, as there is so much that can be done with photography. You don't need a lot to have fun — a camera and decent image editing software will suffice. As much as you may prefer not to use it, Photoshop (or any other image editor) always goes hand in hand with this kind of work. We'll be using Photoshop to alter images so that they look completely over the top.

Illusions

One of the simplest photography tricks is to use perspective in funny ways. A distant object, and a nearby object, when angled correctly to the lense, gives startling results. This can include placing a distant person on a nearby person's hand, or someone about to eat up the sun. Positioning the two elements is paramount. Zoom in to the preview to check if you have got the shot that you need. There is no need to use the macro mode to get these kinds of shots right. Play it safe by taking multiple exposures.

The levitation trick

Most of the photographic illusion trick photos that we see in our mailboxes might seem very complicated, but in fact, making them is quite simple. The levitation trick might seem really difficult to pull off in a video clip but in a still photo, it really is much simpler. In fact, it's something that you can make in under 15 minutes.

We want to give people the impression that the object is hovering over the ground. For this, we need to take a couple of photos. Obviously we can't have an object stay afloat, so we'll need to get the object to be placed on a short stool or a bench. We'll then use a photo without the stool and the object and clear out the stool from underneath it.

We start by taking a suitable position for the camera from where a believable photograph can be taken. We need to make sure that all the photos are taken from the exact same spot, so we'll need a tripod for this trick or at least a sturdy base on which to place the camera.

Step 1: Place the tripod and mount the camera. Make sure to set a manual setting. Try to fix an aperture size, shutter speed, ISO setting for the shot. Use a timer to click the photo so you don't have to manually operate the shutter release mechanism. This eliminates any chances of blurry images due to shaking of the tripod or your hand. You could also use a remote camera control.

Step 2: Take a photo of a scene without the object in place. Use the same steps and settings that you used for the previous step but now remove the stool and the object.

Step 3: Copy the captured images to your hard drive and open it in Photoshop or any other image editor you've been using.

Step 4: Open the two images in Photoshop (See Figure 1) and double-click the first image so that it becomes a new layer. (See figure 2) Now, open the other image, select the entire image by pressing [Ctrl] + [A] then, copy the second image and add

it as a layer on top. This should happen automatically when you paste the image. Make sure you arrange the layers in such a way that the layer with the object is positioned above the layer without the object (See figure 3).

Step 5: Use the Pen tool and draw an outline around the object (See figure 4). Using the eraser increases the chances for mistakes. A path drawn with the pen tool is more accurate and

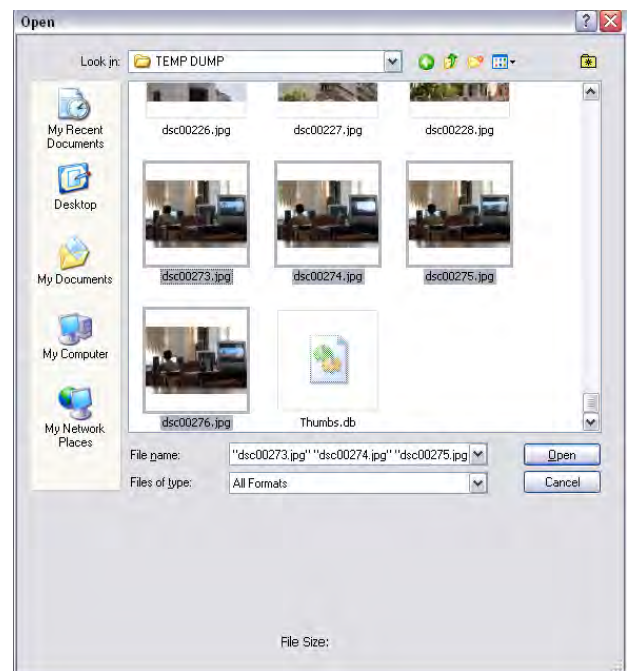


Figure 1: Opening the three slides with Photoshop

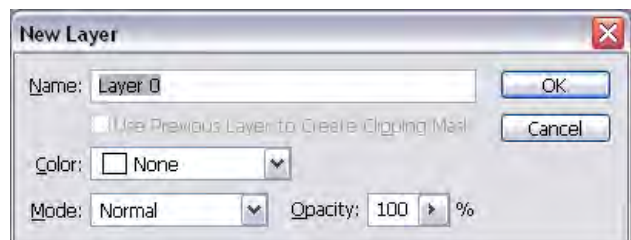


Figure 2: Converting each of the images into a layer

can be modified easily if required. Hold down the mouse, click and draw curves around the object you're trying to cut out. Zoom into the image while you are working on this, and work your way around carefully, adding many nodes. Complete the path.

Step 6: Right-click on the path and click on 'make selection'. (Figure 5) Now invert the selection by clicking on the 'Edit' menu again. The object will be selected now. Delete the selec-